

agencies. We will also enable the brightest minds inside and outside of government to review and improve our code, and work together to ensure that the code is secure, reliable and effective in furthering our national objectives.”

The administration has launched the policy with the aim of fulfilling its commitment to adopt a government-focused open source software policy, which was originally proposed in its Second Open Government National Action Plan. The new law sets out open sharing guidelines for any new custom software that has been built for the US government websites and systems. These could be developed internally or via contracted third-party vendors, apart from cyber security software.



The new policy states that prior to agencies officially commissioning a new custom software development project, they must carry out a thorough ‘alternatives analysis’ to determine whether there is a pre-existing software solution at another agency whose source code can be shared for any important task at hand. Agencies will also need to find out and consider any off-the-shelf software solutions which may be available, before commissioning a custom project.

Even though the new guidelines are not applicable for software programs which were contracted via third parties before the Source Code Policy got published, it strongly motivates agencies to take steps in making those applications available for shared inter-agency use as well.

Linux Foundation and edX bring the Free Open Source Cloud Infrastructure Course

The new Massive Open Online Course (MOOC) will permit individuals worldwide to embark on lucrative careers by building and managing cloud technologies. The Linux Foundation made an announcement that will enable mass innovation via open source. It announced its latest MOOC, which is open for registration.

The MOOC is an introduction to cloud infrastructure technologies and is conducted via edX, the non-profit online learning platform launched in 2012 by Harvard University and Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT). The course is free and will commence from June 2016. The course is the second edX MOOC being offered via the Linux Foundation. The Foundation’s first course, an ‘Intro to Linux’, has attracted over 500,000 students worldwide and continues to grow.



Microsoft releases source code for SONiC

Microsoft has released the source code for Software for Open Networking in the Cloud (SONiC). This is used for running network devices like switches, and has been built in collaboration with leading networking industry vendors Arista, Broadcom, Dell and Mellanox.

This will help in building switches that are rich in functionality. And with SONiC, the hardware’s functionality and applications can reduce the dependence on a proprietary firmware through a traditional networking vendor.

SONiC is based on Microsoft’s Linux-based Azure Cloud Switch (ACS) operating system. ACS is also the brain behind switches in Microsoft’s Azure Cloud. The code is capable of running on various types of hardware from different equipment manufacturers and utilises a common C API – the Switch Abstraction Interface (SAI) for programming the specialist chips in the networking gear. This implies that ACS can be used for controlling and managing network devices. It can also implement the features needed, irrespective of who has manufactured the hardware.

According to Azure’s CTO, Mark Russinovich, “SONiC is a collection of software networking components required to build network devices like switches.”

SONiC can be downloaded from Microsoft’s Azure GitHub repository under a mix of open source licences, which include the GNU GPL and the Apache licence.